

HEIU ENGLISH ACADEMY — ORAL PLACEMENT TEST

Purpose: Determine a new student's real English level through natural conversation.

Duration: 20-30 minutes maximum.

Evaluator: Breagh or Greg (native speakers only).

Format: Ladder — start at A1, move up. When the student breaks down, that's their level.

GENERAL INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE EVALUATOR

- This is a **conversation**, not an exam. Keep it relaxed. Smile. Use their name.
- **Never correct the student.** Just note errors mentally and mark the checklist.
- Ask the question naturally. If they don't understand, rephrase ONCE. If they still can't, mark it as a fail.
- You don't need to ask every single question — if it's obvious they're passing or failing, move on.
- **Trust your gut:** If someone is clearly A1 within 3 minutes, you don't need to spend 5 minutes proving it.
- Use transition phrases to keep it feeling like a chat:
 - "Cool, cool. So tell me..."
 - "Interesting! And what about...?"
 - "Nice. So, quick question..."
 - "That's great. Let me ask you something different..."
 - "Oh really? So..."

Start the conversation like this:

"Hey [name], nice to meet you! So this is just a chat — I want to get to know you a little and see where you're at with English. There's no right or wrong answers, just talk to me naturally, okay? Cool. Let's start."

LEVEL A1 (Minutes 0-5)

Goal: Can they handle basic present simple, modals (can/should/will), and simple WH-questions?

Questions:

1. "So, what do you do? Do you work or study?"

- Structure tested: **Present simple do/does**
- PASS: "I work at a bank." / "I study engineering."
- FAIL: "I working..." / "I am work..." / Total silence.

2. "Nice. And does your mom work too, or does she stay home?"

- Structure tested: **Does + third person**
- PASS: "She works at a school." / "No, she doesn't work."
- FAIL: "She work..." / "She don't work..." / Doesn't understand "does."

3. "What time do you usually wake up?"

- Structure tested: **What time + present simple + time expression**
- PASS: "I wake up at seven." / "At six thirty."
- FAIL: Can't produce a time. Says "I waking seven."

4. "And where do you eat lunch? At home or at work?"

- Structure tested: **Where + present simple**
- PASS: "I eat lunch at work." / "At home, with my family."
- FAIL: Doesn't understand "where" or can't form a basic answer.

5. "Do you play any sports? Like soccer or basketball?"

- Structure tested: **Do you + verb**
- PASS: "Yes, I play soccer." / "No, I don't play sports."
- FAIL: "Yes, I playing..." / Can't form yes/no answer.

6. "Can you cook?"

- Structure tested: **Can/can't + short answer**
- PASS: "Yes, I can." / "No, I can't, but my wife can."
- FAIL: "Yes, I cooking." / Doesn't recognize "can" as a question.

7. "What can you cook? Or what's your best dish?"

- Structure tested: **Can + vocabulary**
- PASS: "I can make pasta." / "I can cook rice and chicken."
- FAIL: Unable to use "can" in their answer.

8. "If you feel sick, should you go to work or stay home?"

- Structure tested: **Should**
- PASS: "I should stay home." / "You should rest."
- FAIL: Doesn't understand "should" or answers without it entirely.

9. "What will you do this weekend?"

- Structure tested: **Will/won't for future**
- PASS: "I will visit my mom." / "I'll go to the park."
- FAIL: "I go park..." / Uses present tense only. No "will."

10. "How much does a coffee cost here in [city]?"

- Structure tested: **How much + does + numbers/prices**
- PASS: "It costs like two dollars." / "Maybe fifteen thousand pesos."
- FAIL: Can't produce a number or doesn't understand "how much."

11. "Tell me about your family. Do you have brothers or sisters?"

- Structure tested: **Subject pronouns + present simple -s**

- PASS: "Yes, I have two brothers. He works in... My sister lives in..."
- FAIL: Mixes up he/she constantly. Can't produce third person -s at all.

12. "Where should I go if I visit your city? What's good?"

- Structure tested: **Should (advice) + places**
- PASS: "You should go to the park." / "You should visit the old town."
- FAIL: Can't use "should" to give advice.

A1 DECISION:

- **PASS (6+ structures used correctly):** Move to A2. Say: "Great, your English is good! Let me ask you some more things..."
- **FAIL (fewer than 6):** STOP. Place in A1. Say: "Awesome, thanks for chatting with me! That's all I needed."

LEVEL A2 (Minutes 5-12)

Goal: Can they handle future forms, conditionals, past continuous, and present perfect?

Questions:

1. "So, do you have any plans for the weekend? What are you going to do?"

- Structure tested: **Going to (planned future)**
- PASS: "I'm going to visit my parents." / "I'm going to study."
- FAIL: "I will visit..." for a clearly planned event. Or "I go visit..."

2. "And is there anything you might do but you're not sure yet?"

- Structure tested: **Might (possibility)**
- PASS: "I might go to the movies." / "I might visit a friend."
- FAIL: Doesn't understand "might" or says "maybe I go..." without the modal.

3. "Let's say next Saturday there's a concert at 8pm. How would you tell a friend about it?"

- Structure tested: **Present simple for scheduled events**
- PASS: "The concert starts at 8." / "It begins at eight o'clock."
- FAIL: "The concert will start..." / Can't distinguish scheduled from planned.

4. "If you have free time tomorrow, what will you do?"

- Structure tested: **First conditional (if + present, will + base)**
- PASS: "If I have time, I will go to the gym." / "I'll read a book if I have time."
- FAIL: "If I will have..." / "If I have, I go..."

5. "Okay, imagine this: if you had a million dollars right now, what would you do?"

- Structure tested: **Second conditional (if + past, would + base)**
- PASS: "If I had a million dollars, I would travel the world." / "I'd buy a house."
- FAIL: "If I have million, I will buy..." / Can't shift to hypothetical.

6. "Have you ever traveled to another country?"

- Structure tested: **Present perfect (have + past participle)**
- PASS: "Yes, I have. I've been to Mexico." / "No, I haven't, but I want to."
- FAIL: "Yes, I travel to Mexico last year." / Doesn't recognize "have you ever."

7. "Tell me about yesterday. What were you doing at 3pm?"

- Structure tested: **Past continuous (was/were + -ing)**
- PASS: "I was working." / "I was watching TV at home."
- FAIL: "I work." / "I watched." (simple past only, no continuous sense)

8. "What happened? Were you doing something when someone called you or interrupted you?"

- Structure tested: **Past continuous + when/while interruption**
- PASS: "I was cooking when my phone rang." / "While I was driving, I saw an accident."
- FAIL: "I cook and the phone ring." / Can't combine the two tenses.

9. "I think that English is important for work. Do you think that too? What do you think about English?"

- Structure tested: **Relative pronoun "that" for opinions**
- PASS: "I think that English is very important." / "I believe that it helps you get better jobs."
- FAIL: Drops "that" entirely and can't form complex opinion sentences.

10. "When's your birthday? And what's today's date?"

- Structure tested: **Ordinal numbers and dates**
- PASS: "My birthday is on March twenty-third." / "Today is the eighth of April."
- FAIL: "My birthday March twenty-three." / Can't produce ordinals.

11. "If it rains during your vacation, what will you do?"

- Structure tested: **During/while + first conditional**
- PASS: "During the rain, I'll stay in the hotel." / "If it rains while I'm on vacation, I'll visit museums."
- FAIL: Can't use "during" or "while" properly.

A2 DECISION:

- **PASS (7+ structures used correctly):** Move to B1. Say: "You're doing great! Let's keep going, this is fun..."
- **FAIL (fewer than 7):** Place in A2. Say: "Awesome, really good chat! I've got what I need."

LEVEL B1 (Minutes 12-20)

Goal: Can they sustain conversation, tell stories, give detailed opinions, and blend tenses correctly?

Questions/Tasks:

1. "Tell me about a trip you took — where did you go, what happened, and would you go back?"

- Structure tested: **Storytelling with multiple tenses (past simple, past continuous, present perfect, conditional)**

- PASS: Uses 2-3 different tenses. "I went to Cartagena last year. I was staying near the beach. I've always loved the coast. I would definitely go back."
 - FAIL: Only uses one tense. Very short answer. Can't sustain more than 2 sentences.
- 2. "What do you think about social media? Is it good or bad?"**
- Structure tested: **Opinions with reasons + sustained speech**
 - PASS: Gives opinion AND reason. "I think social media is useful because you can connect with people, but I also think that people spend too much time on it."
 - FAIL: "Is good." / "I like." / One sentence, no development.
- 3. "Describe your best friend to me. What do they look like, and what are they like as a person?"**
- Structure tested: **Description with detail (appearance + personality vocabulary)**
 - PASS: "She's tall with dark hair. She's really funny and kind. She's the type of person who always helps others."
 - FAIL: "She is good. She is nice." / Very limited vocabulary, no detail.
- 4. "What had you planned to do before you decided to study English here?"**
- Structure tested: **Past perfect for earlier events**
 - PASS: "I had tried to study online, but it didn't work." / "I had thought about going to another school."
 - FAIL: "I try online before." / No past perfect at all.
- 5. "If you could change one thing about your city, what would you change and why?"**
- Structure tested: **Second conditional + extended reasoning**
 - PASS: "If I could change something, I would improve public transport because it's too slow and people waste a lot of time."
 - FAIL: Short answer with no reasoning. Structural errors in the conditional.
- 6. "Tell me about your job or studies. What's a typical day like? I want the whole thing — morning to night."**
- Structure tested: **Sustained conversation (2+ minutes) + present simple routine + vocabulary range**
 - PASS: Speaks for 1-2 minutes. Uses varied vocabulary. Flows naturally. "I usually get up around six. First I check my emails, then I have breakfast while I read the news..."
 - FAIL: Very short. "I wake up. I go work. I come home." Can't sustain or add detail.
- 7. "What are you planning to do in the next five years? Career, personal life, anything."**
- Structure tested: **Future forms blended (going to, will, might, want to, hope to)**
 - PASS: Uses multiple future forms naturally. "I'm going to finish my degree. After that, I might do a master's. I hope to travel more. I'll probably stay in this city."
 - FAIL: Only uses one future form. Very short. "I will work."
- 8. "Can you explain to me how to make your favorite food? Step by step."**
- Structure tested: **Sequencing language + imperatives + vocabulary**
 - PASS: "First, you need to chop the onion. Then you fry it in oil until it's golden. After that, you add the tomatoes..."
 - FAIL: "You put... the... thing... and cook." Very limited, can't sequence.
- 9. "What's something you've been doing lately that you enjoy?"**
- Structure tested: **Present perfect continuous (I've been + -ing)**
 - PASS: "I've been going to the gym a lot." / "I've been reading more."
 - FAIL: "I go gym." / Doesn't recognize or produce the structure.

B1 DECISION:

- **PASS (6+ areas demonstrated competently, can sustain speech):** Move to B2. Say: "Okay, you're really good. Let me push you a little more..."
- **FAIL (fewer than 6, or can't sustain conversation):** Place in B1. Say: "That was a great conversation! Thanks so much."

LEVEL B2 (Minutes 20-28)

Goal: Can they handle advanced grammar, argue a point, and speak fluently on complex topics?

Questions/Tasks:

- 1. "You like traveling, don't you? Or am I wrong?"**
- Structure tested: **Question tags**
 - PASS: Responds naturally AND produces their own question tag. "Yeah, I do! You've been to Europe, haven't you?"
 - FAIL: Confused by the question tag. Can't produce one themselves.
- 2. "Between living in the city or the countryside, which do you prefer? Or would you like both?"**
- Structure tested: **Either/neither/both**
 - PASS: "I like both, actually." / "Neither option is perfect, but I'd choose the city." / "I'd either live downtown or near the mountains."
 - FAIL: Can't use either/neither/both correctly.
- 3. "Imagine you hadn't studied English when you were younger. How would your life be different now?"**
- Structure tested: **Third conditional / mixed conditional**
 - PASS: "If I hadn't studied English, I wouldn't have gotten my current job." / "I might not have met my partner because we met at an English class."
 - FAIL: "If I didn't study, I don't have job." / Can't form the third conditional.
- 4. "Tell me about a famous building or something well-known in your country. When was it built? What's it used for?"**
- Structure tested: **Passive voice**
 - PASS: "It was built in 1920. It's used as a museum now. It was designed by a famous architect."
 - FAIL: "They build it in 1920. People use it for museum." / Active only.
- 5. "Tell me about a conversation you had recently. What did the other person say?"**
- Structure tested: **Reported speech**
 - PASS: "My boss told me that I needed to finish the project by Friday. He said he would help me if I needed it."
 - FAIL: "My boss say 'finish the project.'" / Direct speech only.
- 6. "Have you gotten anything done recently — like a haircut, car repair, something fixed at home?"**
- Structure tested: **Causative (have/get something done)**
 - PASS: "I got my car serviced last week." / "I had my apartment painted."
 - FAIL: "I cut my hair." (meaning someone else did it) / Doesn't know the structure.

7. "Tell me about a person who has influenced you — someone who you admire and whose advice you follow."

- Structure tested: **Relative clauses (who, whose, where, which, that)**

- PASS: "My grandfather, who was a teacher, always told me to work hard. The town where he lived was very small."

- FAIL: Can't produce relative clauses. "My grandfather. He was teacher. He told me work hard."

8. "Do you think everyone should learn a second language? Is there anywhere in the world where it's not necessary? Does anyone really only need one language?"

- Structure tested: **Indefinite pronouns (everyone, anywhere, anyone, nobody, something)**

- PASS: Uses several indefinite pronouns naturally in their response.

- FAIL: Avoids them or uses them incorrectly.

9. **MINI-DEBATE: "Some people say that AI will replace teachers completely. Do you agree or disagree? Argue your point — convince me."**

- Structure tested: **Arguing with evidence + sustained complex speech (3+ minutes)**

- PASS: Speaks for 3+ minutes. Uses examples, concessions ("While it's true that..."), counter-arguments ("However, I believe..."), and conclusions. Fluent with only minor errors.

- FAIL: Can't sustain the argument. Very short. Major grammatical breakdowns. Can't organize thoughts.

10. "Describe a situation where something went wrong but it turned out to be a blessing in disguise."

- Structure tested: **Complex narrative + advanced vocabulary + idiomatic understanding**

- PASS: Tells a detailed story with proper tense use, advanced vocabulary, and clear structure.

- FAIL: Story is disorganized, vocabulary is limited, or major tense errors throughout.

B2 DECISION:

- **PASS (7+ structures demonstrated, fluent extended speech):** Student is B2+. Note this — they may need a C1-level program in the future.

- **FAIL (fewer than 7):** Place in B2. Say: "Wow, your English is really strong. That was a great chat!"

EVALUATOR CHECKLIST

Print this page. Fill it out during the interview.

HEIIU — ORAL PLACEMENT TEST CHECKLIST

Student: _____ Date: _____
Evaluator: _____ Duration: _____ min

A1 STRUCTURES (Minutes 0-5):

- ☐ Subject pronouns (he/she/they used correctly)
 - ☐ Can/can't + short answers
 - ☐ Should (advice)
 - ☐ Will/won't (future)
 - ☐ Numbers / time / prices
 - ☐ Present simple do/does (questions)
 - ☐ Present simple -s (third person)
 - ☐ Where + What time (WH-questions)
- RESULT: ☐ PASS --> continue to A2
☐ FAIL --> PLACE IN A1

Notes: _____

A2 STRUCTURES (Minutes 5-12):

- ☐ Going to (planned future)
 - ☐ Might (possibility)
 - ☐ Present simple for schedules
 - ☐ "That" for opinions (I think that...)
 - ☐ First conditional (if + present, will)
 - ☐ Second conditional (if + past, would)
 - ☐ Past continuous (was/were + -ing)
 - ☐ Present perfect (have/has + past participle)
 - ☐ Ordinal numbers and dates
 - ☐ During / while / when
- RESULT: ☐ PASS --> continue to B1
☐ FAIL --> PLACE IN A2

Notes: _____

B1 STRUCTURES (Minutes 12-20):

- ☐ Multiple tenses used correctly in context
 - ☐ Sustained conversation (2+ minutes)
 - ☐ Storytelling with sequence
 - ☐ Opinions with reasons
 - ☐ Detailed descriptions (people/places)
 - ☐ Vocabulary range (work, travel, daily life)
 - ☐ Present perfect continuous
 - ☐ Sequencing language (first, then, after that)
- RESULT: ☐ PASS --> continue to B2
☐ FAIL --> PLACE IN B1

Notes: _____

B2 STRUCTURES (Minutes 20-28):

☐ Question tags
☐ Either / neither / both
☐ Third conditional / mixed conditional
☐ Passive voice
☐ Reported speech
☐ Causative (have/get something done)
☐ Relative clauses (who, whose, where, which)
☐ Indefinite pronouns (everyone, something, anywhere)
☐ Argues a point with evidence
☐ 3+ minutes fluent speech on complex topic
RESULT: ☐ PASS --> B2+ (may need C1 assessment)
☐ FAIL --> PLACE IN B2
Notes: _____

FINAL PLACEMENT

☐ A1 ☐ A2 ☐ B1 ☐ B2 ☐ B2+

General observations: _____

Confidence level: ☐ Very clear ☐ Borderline

If borderline, between which levels? _____ and _____

Evaluator signature: _____
=====

QUICK REFERENCE: TIMING GUIDE

| If student is really... | You'll know by... | Total test time |

---|---|---

| A1 | Minute 3-5 | 5 minutes |

| A2 | Minute 8-12 | 12 minutes |

| B1 | Minute 15-18 | 18 minutes |

| B2 | Minute 22-28 | 25-28 minutes |

| B2+ | Minute 28 | 28-30 minutes |

TIPS FOR NATURAL FLOW

Opening warmup (30 seconds):

"Hey! How are you? How was your day getting here?"

(This is NOT assessed — just to relax them.)

Transitioning between levels:

- A1 to A2: "Cool, so you clearly speak some English! Let me ask you about some other stuff..."

- A2 to B1: "Nice, you're doing great. Let's have more of a real conversation now..."

- B1 to B2: "Okay, you're really good. I'm going to challenge you a bit, cool?"

Ending early (student is clearly struggling):

"Hey, that was great! Thanks for chatting with me. I have a good idea of where you're at."

(Never say "you failed" or "your level is low.")

If student asks "How did I do?":

"You did great! We'll let you know your group soon."

(Never reveal placement on the spot — coordination handles that.)

IMPORTANT REMINDERS

1. **DO NOT correct errors.** Your job is to observe, not teach.
2. **DO NOT tell the student their level.** Just say you'll be in touch.
3. **DO NOT rush.** Give them time to think. Silence is okay.
4. **DO NOT read questions robotically.** Memorize the gist and make it conversational.
5. **Trust the ladder.** If they can't do A1, don't test A2 "just to be sure."
6. **Mark the checklist as you go.** Don't try to remember everything after.
7. **Borderline cases:** If someone is between two levels, place them in the LOWER level. They can always move up.